# GOZO TOWNHOUSES OF THE 1920s

Architectural character, village life and the historical setting of a traditional townhouse in Xagħra, Gozo

Townhouses built in Gozo during the 1920s belong to a period in which long-established Maltese building traditions continued alongside changing ideas about domestic comfort and architectural presentation. Their enduring appeal comes from their limestone construction, craftsmanship and close relationship with village life.

## 1 Typical architectural features

No two houses are identical, and not every feature below will be present in an individual property. Common characteristics of traditional Gozitan townhouses include:

- Limestone masonry. Thick walls of locally quarried stone, providing substantial thermal mass and a recognisably Gozitan appearance.
- High ceilings and generous proportions. Often used to improve air circulation and create comfortable living rooms.
- Patterned cement tiles. Geometric or floral floor designs reflecting early twentieth-century taste and craftsmanship.
- Traditional roof construction. Timber beams and stone slabs (often called xorok) in some houses, although roofs may have been altered over time.
- Stone staircases and ironwork. Practical structural elements sometimes complemented by decorative details.
- Wooden shutters, balconies and doors. These provided shade, ventilation, privacy and distinctive street character.
- Courtyards and roof terraces. Useful for daylight, airflow and everyday family activities.

## 2 Gozo in the 1920s

During the 1920s, Gozo was part of Malta under British rule, while village society retained its strong Mediterranean character. Agriculture, local trades, family networks and parish life remained important. Townhouses were generally situated within established settlements and reflected the needs and aspirations of their residents.

Local stoneworking and traditional construction methods continued, while the appearance and arrangement of some homes showed broader European and British-period influences. Decorative façades and more formal domestic layouts coexisted with practical features adapted to the Mediterranean climate.

## 3 Townhouse versus farmhouse

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| Typically situated along a village street | Often associated with rural land and agriculture |
| Street-facing façade, sometimes decorative | Often simpler and more utilitarian exterior |
| Principal focus on domestic family living | May originally have included agricultural workspaces |
| Formal staircases and decorative floors may appear | Frequently more functional interior finishes |

## 4 The architectural character of Xagħra

Xagħra is known for a historic village setting in which limestone houses, townhouses and older rural building traditions sit close together. Street-facing façades, worked stone, doors, balconies and rooflines contribute to the village’s character. The exact age and original use of an individual building should be assessed from documentary evidence and its surviving fabric.

## 5 Your townhouse at 19 Triq il-Knisja

The property is understood to date from the 1920s, although its exact year of construction is not established here. Its period makes it part of the broader story of early twentieth-century village housing in Gozo.

To develop a more property-specific account, particularly interesting details to record are the stonework, original floor tiles, staircase, window and door joinery, layout, roof structure and any evidence of later modifications. Those details should be documented before describing them as original.

## 6 Suggested brochure wording

A Century of Gozitan Character

Dating from the 1920s, this traditional townhouse in the historic village of Xagħra offers a connection to Gozo’s architectural heritage.

Built during a period when local craftsmanship and Mediterranean traditions met the influences of early twentieth-century design, homes of this era are celebrated for their limestone construction, generous proportions and distinctive character.

Today, the residence combines its historical setting with contemporary comforts. With thoughtfully appointed interiors, a roof terrace, views and a hot tub, it offers guests a distinctive alternative to conventional accommodation.

## Further research

For a more precise historical account, consider historic photographs of Xagħra, local planning and building records, old title documents and a survey of surviving architectural details. The Gozo Album photographic archive and the University of Malta’s open-access repository are useful starting points.

Gozo Album: https://gozoalbum.gov.mt/ | University of Malta repository: https://www.um.edu.mt/library/oar/

Historical note: This is a general architectural and social history, not a verified building-history report for 19 Triq il-Knisja. Architectural features listed here should not automatically be attributed to that property.